

A COZY MURDER MYSTERY PARTY GAME

The

Gravy Boat MURDER

A Cozy Friendsgiving Murder Mystery

6-12 PLAYERS · 90 MIN-2.5 HOURS · PRINTABLE PDF

HOST GUIDE · SPOILER-FREE

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

READ THIS FIRST · NO SPOILERS INSIDE

Host *Guide*



Everything you need to run The Gravy Boat Murder, even if you have never hosted a mystery before. This guide never reveals the answer, so you can play along.

How the game works

1. **Every guest gets a character and a dish.** Each character booklet names a dish to bring, so your potluck menu is planned the moment you cast the game.
2. **Three rounds, three courses:** Appetizers, The Main Course and Pie. Each round you read a short script and put out four evidence cards.
3. **Guests mingle**, share what their booklet tells them to share, ask two named characters a question and try a small social mission.
4. **Accusation over coffee.** Everyone fills in a ballot: who, how, why and the key evidence.
5. **The reveal.** One player opens the sealed solution (file 99) and reads Script 5 aloud. You score the ballots and hand out the awards.

Your job as host

- Cast the game, send invitations and fill in the Potluck Planner (file 04).
- Keep time, read Scripts 1–4 and put out each round's evidence.
- Keep things moving and make sure quiet guests get asked questions.

> CAN THE HOST PLAY?
> Yes. Take booklet 10 (Avery Quill) or booklet 11 (Sage Montrose) and play like everyone else, or simply narrate. Ask another guest or a family member to cut the evidence cards and fill the three envelopes, so you have not seen them either.

> DON'T OPEN FILE 99
> **99-SOLUTION-Open-Last** holds the answer. Don't open it, don't print-preview it. Print it last and face down, or keep it on a phone until every ballot is in.

Preparation Checklist

Two weeks before

- [ ] Pick the date and the version: Full (140 minutes) or Express (90 minutes).
- [ ] Confirm your guest count (6–12; up to 16 with shared booklets).
- [ ] Use the casting chart (page 4) to choose the booklets.
- [ ] Decide whether you will play (booklet 10 or 11) or narrate.
- [ ] Send invitations (file 02, or the text version on its last page).

One week before

- [ ] Send each guest their character, booklet number and dish.
- [ ] Fill in the Potluck Planner (file 04) and ask about allergies.
- [ ] Share the Cast List (file 03) so people can plan outfits.
- [ ] Plan drinks (page 13): all alcohol-free.
- [ ] Buy envelopes, pens, tape or pins, and coffee for the accusation.

Two or three days before

- [ ] Print the files on the print list in file 00.
- [ ] Ask a helper to cut the evidence cards and fill three envelopes: Appetizers (E1–E4), Main Course (E5–E8), Pie (E9–E12).
- [ ] Print booklets single-sided; cut page 3 on its dashed line if you like.
- [ ] Cut name tags, ballots, dish tents, round tents and banner pennants.
- [ ] Seal file 99 in an envelope marked “Open last.”

On the day

- [ ] Hang the WHO SPOILED THE GRAVY? banner.
- [ ] Set the buffet with the dish tents and the Juniper Barn sign.
- [ ] Set an Evidence table with its “Please Do Not Eat” sign.
- [ ] Lay out name tags, booklets, pens and Detective Notes.
- [ ] Keep this guide and the three envelopes beside you.

Your party plan

DATE _____

START TIME _____

VERSION (FULL / EXPRESS) _____

NUMBER OF PLAYERS _____

CARD-CUTTING HELPER _____

HOST PLAYS BOOKLET 10, 11 OR NARRATES _____

COFFEE MAKER READY _____

BALLOT BOWL _____

Casting Chart

6-12 PLAYERS

Count everyone who will hold a booklet, including you if you play. The six core booklets (10–15) are in every game; optional booklets are added in number order, 16 first.

PLAYERS	BOOKLETS TO USE	BOOKLET PAGES
6	10–15 (the six core booklets)	6 × 4 = 24
7	10–16 (adds 16 Harper Lindqvist)	7 × 4 = 28
8	10–17 (adds 17 Skyler Bontempo)	8 × 4 = 32
9	10–18 (adds 18 Arden Fairweather)	9 × 4 = 36
10	10–19 (adds 19 Indigo Pike)	10 × 4 = 40
11	10–20 (adds 20 Charlie Okonjo)	11 × 4 = 44
12	10–21 (adds 21 Wren Abernathy)	12 × 4 = 48

HOST'S BOOKLET

If you want to play, take **booklet 10 (Avery Quill)** or **booklet 11 (Sage Montrose)**. Hand out every other booklet however you like: every character works for anyone, and every booklet uses names and "they," never he or she.

13–16 guests: share a booklet

GUESTS	BOOKLETS	SHARED AS DUOS
13	10–21	21 Wren Abernathy
14	10–21	20 Charlie Okonjo and 21 Wren Abernathy
15	10–21	19, 20 and 21
16	10–21	18, 19, 20 and 21

Duos read one booklet together and play one character as a team (two cousins, two old friends). Print an extra name tag from the blank ones. Fewer than 6 guests? Try our free 4–6 player mini mystery, The Case of the Cold Cocoa.

Timetables

Full version · 140 minutes

A Friendsgiving dinner party: dinner is served during Round 2.

PART	MINUTES
Arrival, dishes on the buffet, name tags	15
Script 1 (opening) and reading page 2	10
Round 1 · Appetizers	25
Round 2 · The Main Course (eat while you play)	35
Round 3 · Pie	25
Accusation over coffee (ballots)	10
The reveal (Script 5)	10
Scoring and awards	10
Total	**140**

Express · 90 minutes

After a family Thanksgiving meal or an office potluck lunch.

PART	MINUTES
Welcome, Script 1 and reading page 2	10
Round 1 · Appetizers	15
Round 2 · The Main Course	20
Round 3 · Pie	15
Accusation over coffee (ballots)	10
The reveal (Script 5)	10
Scoring and awards	10
Total	**90**

EXPRESS SHORTCUTS

Let guests read page 2 while plates are cleared, keep missions quick and serve pie during Round 3.

Your party clock

Write in real clock times, so you know at a glance when to start each part.

GUESTS ARRIVE _____

SCRIPT 1 _____

ROUND 1 STARTS _____

ROUND 2 STARTS _____

ROUND 3 STARTS _____

COFFEE AND BALLOTS _____

THE REVEAL _____

AWARDS _____

ONLY 60 MINUTES?

Keep all three rounds (the evidence is spread across them) but give each one 10 minutes, with 15 for The Main Course. Read Script 1 as people sit down: welcome 5, Round 1 10, Round 2 15, Round 3 10, ballots 5, reveal 10, scoring 5 = 60 minutes. Skip the awards or hand them out the next day.

Setting Up

The evidence envelopes

Ask a helper who is not playing (or a guest who arrives early) to cut the evidence cards from file 30. If you print the optional card backs on the reverse, they can cut face down. They sort the cards into three envelopes:

- **Appetizers envelope:** E1, E2, E3, E4.
- **Main Course envelope:** E5, E6, E7, E8.
- **Pie envelope:** E9, E10, E11, E12.

Each card is labeled with its round in words, so sorting is easy even in black and white.

The room

- A buffet with each dish beside its table tent (file 04, page 2).
- An Evidence table where everyone can read the cards without taking them.
- The round table tent for the current course, turned to face the room.
- A ballot bowl (any bowl, hat or empty pie tin) and a pot of coffee.
- A quiet corner where people can read their booklets privately.

The booklets

Hand each guest their booklet at the door, or send the PDF ahead. Page 1 can be read before the party (it has the outfit ideas and the dish). Page 2 waits until Script 1; pages 3 and 4 wait for the rounds. If you cut page 3 on its dashed line, hand out the Round 2 half when Round 2 starts.

> HOST TIP
> If guests arrive in waves, let early birds set out their dishes and swap outfit compliments. Start Script 1 when everyone has a name tag and a plate of appetizers.

Script 1 · Opening

READ ALOUD

Read this when everyone has a name tag and a booklet. Take your time and pause for gasps.

READ ALOUD

Welcome, everyone, to Juniper Barn and the tenth annual Friendsgiving! For ten years this circle of friends has shared one long table, one potluck and one cookbook, The Juniper Barn Cookbook, written together recipe by recipe. And every year the meal begins the same way: Marigold Ashby, known to us all as Goldie, star of Supper with Goldie and our Gravy Queen, tastes the very first spoonful of gravy from her antique silver gravy boat.

This afternoon Goldie made her famous gravy in the kitchen. At half past five she poured her tasting portion into the silver boat and set it on the pantry's warming shelf, with strict orders: nobody touches my boat. At six o'clock sharp she carried it to the head table, tasted, smiled and said, "Perfect. And after dinner I have news that will change all of us." At ten past six Goldie said she felt terribly tired, settled into her rocking chair by the woodstove and closed her eyes.

When dinner was served at twenty to seven, Goldie would not wake. She had passed away, peacefully, in her chair. Dr. Linden, who lives down the lane, has been and gone, and says this was no accident. The creek has flooded the Juniper Lane bridge, so nobody leaves tonight. Every guest here brought a dish. Every guest had a reason.

Please open your booklet and read page 2 quietly now. Don't turn to page 3 until I start Round 1. Innocent characters may dodge questions about their secrets until their booklet says to share; only one person here may lie outright. Nobody may change what an evidence card says. Let's find out who spoiled the gravy.

AFTER READING

Give everyone about five minutes for page 2, then start Script 2.

Script 2 · Round 1

Turn the Appetizers tent to face the room. Open the Appetizers envelope.

READ ALOUD

Round one: Appetizers. Grab some soup or a cracker from the cheese board, and open your booklet to page 3. Read the top half, Round 1, only.

I am placing four pieces of evidence on the Evidence table: numbers one, two, three and four. Read them, but leave them there for everyone. Look closely at the map of the barn; you will want it later.

You have about twenty-five minutes. Share what your booklet tells you to share, ask your two questions and try your mission. Start with someone you haven't talked to yet. Good luck, detectives.

HOST NOTES

- Put E1–E4 on the Evidence table.
- Give a five-minute warning before the round ends.
- If a corner goes quiet, ask: "Who has asked you a question yet?"

Script 3 · Round 2

Turn The Main Course tent to face the room. Open the Main Course envelope. This is a good moment to serve dinner.

READ ALOUD

Round two: The Main Course. Please fill your plates; we can eat and investigate at the same time. While you were all busy with the appetizers, Dr. Linden sent a note about exactly what was in that gravy boat, and a few other things have turned up around the barn.

Please read the lower half of page 3, Round 2. Do not turn to page 4. I am placing evidence five, six, seven and eight on the Evidence table. Read them closely: tonight, times matter. Think hard about who could have reached that gravy boat, and when.

You have about thirty-five minutes in the full version. Ask your two questions, share your new information and try your mission. If someone dodged you in Round 1, ask them again.

HOST NOTES

- Put E5–E8 on the Evidence table.
- Encourage people to fill in the timeline on their Detective Notes.
- Express version: 20 minutes for this round.

Script 4 • Round 3

Turn the Pie tent to face the room. Open the Pie envelope and bring out the pies.

READ ALOUD

Round three: Pie. Something was hidden in this barn tonight, and someone's story does not fit the clock. Please turn to page 4 of your booklet and read Round 3.

I am placing evidence nine, ten, eleven and twelve on the Evidence table. This is the last evidence of the night, so look at all twelve cards together. You have about twenty-five minutes: ask, share and try your final mission.

Accusation over coffee

When Round 3 ends, pour the coffee (or tea, or more cider) and hand out the ballots.

READ ALOUD

Detectives, it is time to accuse. Please take a ballot and write who spoiled the gravy, how they did it and why, plus up to three evidence numbers that prove it. No conferring. Fold your ballot and drop it in the bowl. When every ballot is in, one of you will open the sealed solution and read us the truth.

HOST NOTES

Put E9–E12 on the Evidence table. Allow about ten minutes for ballots.

How to Reveal

1. **Collect every ballot.** Keep the bowl to one side.
2. **Ask for a volunteer to read the solution.** Any player can do it, and so can you. Hand them the sealed file 99. Page 1 says STOP; that is fine, because every ballot is in.
3. **The reader turns to page 4, Script 5**, and reads it aloud to the room. Script 5 reveals who did it and walks through the clues.
4. **Let the person responsible take a bow.** Applause is mandatory.
5. **Score the ballots** with the scoring rules on page 5 of file 99 (also printed on the ballot sheet): Who 3 · How 2 · Why 2 · up to 3 evidence points.
6. **Give the awards** from file 34: Best Detective (highest score), Best Performance and Best Dish (vote by applause).

READ ALOUD (BEFORE THE REVEAL)

Every ballot is in. Our volunteer will now open the solution and read us Script 5. Everyone else, keep your theories to yourselves for one more minute.

TIES

If two detectives tie on points, the one who named more correct evidence numbers wins. Still tied? Whoever brought the best dish decides.

PHOTO MOMENT

Line everyone up behind the WHO SPOILED THE GRAVY? banner, with the person responsible in the middle holding a gravy boat (empty, of course).

Hosting Tips

Keeping it moving

- Give a five-minute warning before each round ends.
- If someone is stuck, ask them to read their "Share" lines aloud to the room.
- Quiet guest? Ask them one of your own questions, or ask a talkative player to "interview" them.
- Running late? Shorten Rounds 1 and 3 first; never skip a round, because every round holds evidence.

Big groups

- **13–16 guests:** pairs share optional booklets as duos (see the casting chart).
- **17–24 guests:** run two tables, each with its own set of booklets and evidence. Both tables play the same rounds at the same time, then compare ballots. Print the kit twice.
- **Families with kids under 12:** let a younger child team up with a parent as a duo and be the "evidence reader."

Keeping it kind

- The game is PG and clean: no drinking tasks, no flirting, nothing gory. Grandparents, teens (12+) and coworkers are welcome.
- Nobody has to act. Reading a line straight from the booklet is perfectly fine.
- Goldie is never described in a scary way: she simply never wakes from a nap in her rocking chair.

> PLAYING AGAIN?
> Each group can only solve the mystery once, but the kit is reusable: print fresh booklets, ballots and Detective Notes, and lend the whole set to a friend for their own Friendsgiving.

Drinks & Table Setting

ALL ALCOHOL-FREE

Every drink idea here is alcohol-free, so teens, grandparents and designated drivers are all included.

Drinks

- **Hot spiced apple cider:** Quinn's signature, alcohol-free. Warm apple juice with cinnamon sticks, cloves and orange slices; keep it in a slow cooker.
- **Cranberry-orange sparkler:** cranberry juice, orange juice and sparkling water over ice with a rosemary sprig.
- **Maple spice coffee:** for the accusation: coffee with a spoon of maple syrup, cinnamon and cream.
- **Pumpkin spice hot cocoa:** for the kids and the cocoa lovers.

Table setting

- A plaid or burlap table runner with mini pumpkins and fallen leaves.
- The dish tents beside each dish, and the Juniper Barn sign at the head of the table.
- A gravy boat (or any jug) as a centerpiece prop. Keep it empty.
- Candles in jars, a pile of pens and a stack of Detective Notes.
- A rocking chair or armchair with a plaid blanket, for atmosphere.

> **EVIDENCE TABLE**
> Use a side table with the "Evidence: Please Do Not Eat" sign, so nobody sets a pie on Evidence #9.

Potluck & Allergies

The game's potluck menu is built in: each character brings one dish, listed on the invitation, the booklet, the Cast List, the Potluck Planner and the dish tents.

Planning the menu

- Six players give you soup, pie, cider, cranberry sauce, stuffing and scalloped potatoes. As more players join, the table grows: root vegetables, cornbread, green bean casserole, turkey, a cheese board and rolls.
- Not playing with 19 Indigo Pike? You (or anyone) can still cook the turkey; the dish just isn't part of the game.
- Store-bought always counts. Swap any dish for an easier one; the clues never depend on the food.

Allergies and diets

- Ask about allergies when you send invitations and write them in the Potluck Planner.
- Every dish tent has an "Allergens" line. Fill it in with a pen when the dish arrives.
- Vegetarian guests: the soup, sides, pie, cornbread, cheese board and rolls can all be meat-free.

Oven and fridge traffic

- Ask guests to bring dishes ready to serve or ready to reheat for 20 minutes.
- Warm dishes during Round 1 and serve the main course in Round 2.
- Keep pies out of sight until Round 3: it makes a lovely entrance.

Printing & Folding

LETTER OR A4

- **Paper size:** use the US-Letter or the A4 folder to match your paper. Print at “Actual size” or 100%.
- **Black and white is fine.** Every round, card and optional character is labeled in words, not only by color.
- **Booklets (10–21): print single-sided.** Page 3 can then be cut on its dashed line, so Round 2 is handed out separately and later rounds can’t show through. File 22 holds all twelve booklets in one file for one-click printing.
- **Evidence cards (30):** pages 1–2 are the cards; page 3 is optional card backs. Print page 3 on the back of pages 1 and 2 so your helper can cut face down, or skip it to save ink.
- **Invitations (02), name tags (31), ballots (32):** cut on the dashed lines.
- **Potluck tents (04 page 2) and awards and decor (34):** cut on the dashed lines and fold tents on the dotted lines.
- **Detective Notes (33):** one copy per player.
- **Ballots (32):** one sheet for every four players.
- **Solution (99):** print it last, face down, without looking. Or keep it on a phone.

> CARD STOCK
> Name tags, table tents and award certificates look best on light card stock (65–80 lb / 170–220 gsm). Everything else prints on ordinary paper.

> BOOKLETS ON PHONES
> Every booklet is its own PDF, so you can text it to a guest. Ask them to read only page 1 before the party, and not to scroll ahead.